

Géricault

Exemplifying the Romantic movement, Théodore Géricault (1791–1824) was inspired by Delacroix and influenced many other artists in turn. By exploring emotionally heightened themes with marked realism, he expressed human experiences such as suffering, death and triumph. A painter and lithographer, his disregard for convention helped to elevate him to legendary status during a tragically short career of just 12 years.

After studying with Neoclassical painter Pierre-Narcisse Guérin (1774–1833) and copying works in the Louvre, Géricault initially painted with a strong influence of Rubens. After two years in Italy, he also began integrating elements of Caravaggio's chiaroscuro and Michelangelo's drama. Soon, his personal energy and emotional intensity took over, as he disregarded traditional history painting styles and broke with convention. His impassioned, larger than life-sized 1819 painting, *The Raft of the Medusa*, with its morbid depiction of human suffering, drama and strongly contrasting effects of light, proved highly controversial.



Géricault, *The Raft of the Medusa*, 1819